THE LADIES CARTEL

A BOX FULL OF SURPRISES

Photograph by **BANDEEP SINGH**



Women are ruling the roost on Indian streaming as more female-fronted web series get greenlit and find favour. Netflix's latest original show, *Dabba Cartel*, only confirms this, as it trends #1 on the platform. Created by Shibani Akhtar and billed as 'Narcos Thane', it centres on five women who start a tiffin service, although the contents of the dabbas are anything but legal.

Streaming is also where the meatier parts are coming to actresses, regardless of their age. "It was really not thinkable, even 20 years ago, that a woman of the age that I am would play the central figure," said Shabana who, at 74, headlines the show. On OTT, content takes precedence over box office collections. The shelf life is also longer, which means "writers and producers get the courage to make different content", she added.

With six central female characters—Azmi, Jyothika, Nimisha Sajayan, Shalini Pandey, Anjali Anand and Sai Tamhankar—the series stands out with its strong characterisation. Shibani admits that she lucked out in getting a talented cast who were secure and assured and put the project upfront. "There is this excitement and understanding that you are sharing space with people that are an integral part of the story," Shibani said. "When you allow for that to happen, the story becomes more beautiful."

Women are women's worst enemies was a myth that was busted on the sets of the show. It's what made the process of shooting the show easy. "I realised that women are out there just waiting to uplift each other," Jyothika said. "We didn't question each other's role, we didn't have any debate and we enjoyed our work." ■

DABBA DELIGHT

All three artists shared not just what they'd like in their dabba but also that of their significant other. While Shaban picked samosa and only samosa and Jyothika said she'd share her South Indian breakfast dabba with her actor-husband, Suriya, Shibani opted for junk food in French fries, chocolate chip cookies and doughnuts